# Refugee Women – A Collection

## By Haymanot Tesfa, Julia Alvarez and Warsan Shire

## This Matter by Haymanot Tesfa

*Haymanot Tesfa is a singer and artist from Ethiopia, and a member of the @FreefromTorture "Write to Life" group who are all survivors of torture and have experienced detention in the UK. Since her arrival in England, she has had three spells of detention in Yarls Wood Centre.*

("This matter occupied the time
of the Court from 10.20 a.m. to 10.28 a.m.")

Eight minutes they gave
for the light of me
to be switched on or switched off.

But that was O.K..
All that was on the agenda
was my small past,
my small future -

only a bangle of handcuffs
that suited my tiny hands;

only being dragged by the arms
so it polished the lucky airport floor
and saved me walking;
only three times staying

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behind the eleven locked doors
of my holiday home.

I cried every day
but it wasn't too bad.
My tears cleaned my cheeks.

Eight minutes they gave.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Haymanot Tesfa***
***Book: Conversation Poetry Quarterly; Summer 2009 & Refugee Week Special #8, Pg 24***
***ISSN: 1759-9393***
***Publisher: The Conversation Paperpress***
***Date (Month/Year): Summer 2009***

***https://issuu.com/conversationpoetry/docs/volume_8_summer_2009***

## INTRODUCTION

*The United Nations High Commission for Refugees (UNHCR) reports in June of 2021 that of the 82.4 million people who have been forced into displacement, over half are women and girls. Furthermore, 1 in 5 women refugees experience sexual violence – they are kidnapped, trafficked, or forced into marriage. And as health crises combine with conflict, we know that women survivors seeking refuge need our support now more than ever.*

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*I challenge you today to listen. Listen and put yourself in place of these desperate refugees. It's not a question of **if** it could happen, it's that it **has** happened, to hundreds of thousands of women and children. Human lives. Lives we could help. Listen, recognize the tragic humanity, and above all else DO something. You can start by visiting RefugeesInternational.org*

*Refugee Women – A Collection by Haymanot Tesfa, Julia Alvarez and Warsan Shire*

## Refugee Women by Julia Alvarez

These women without countries,
these widows from Salvador,
these matchstick dreamers, these quick-bone
little sisters from Cambodia,
these somber Argentine matrons,
where are we going to put them?
Isabel, Margarita,
Yoeum, Yat, Alicia,
and almond-pretty Sunhee?
The men are mostly dead,
Fernando and Francisco,
hurled in the holes they dug.
(They can hardly call it a burial.)

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Now they're the crusted soil
these women scrape from their soles
on the welcome mats of our doorsteps.
Widowed, orphaned, exiled –
countless times they've been violated.
(What accounts are being kept?)

Mothers, daughters, sisters
and girlfriends to the dead –
these women without countries
get through Customs with their ghosts
and haunt our United States.
They who have known the rod,
dry ice, gray rats, live wire,
grow humble.
Each thank you and goodbye
practiced before a mirror
so the face does not betray
the slightest hint of ingratitude –

Isabel, Yoeum, Yat,
Margarita, Amelia, Sunhee,

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how will you survive
in this country club of a country,
remember but not recall
the dead you left behind you,
the small bundle of a child,
how the body empties of self
at the moment of violation?
You who have not yet arrived
to the warm brown of your bodies,
to the names we hope will recall you:
Alicia, Amelia, Yoeum,
Sunhee, Yat, Margarita.
Answer us, are you with us?
Did we rescue you in time?
Isabel and Alicia!
We have taught you to use our language;
But by the blank in your eyes,
your smiles faint like old scars
on the emptiness of your faces,
we know you did not survive
the dead you carry inside you.

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These dead with the dead inside them,
in our hand-me-downs,
apologizing in broken English, thanking us
for this sweater, this slice of ham,
this Barbie doll for a daughter.
On the news, they watch for faces
of a cousin or compadre.
But everyone looks familiar
on this telecast of the holocaust.
Our journalists bear witness
holding microphones to fresh corpses.
We try to keep count of death
with an abacus of conscience
repeating their names like prayers:
Yoeum, Yat, Amelia,
Margarita, Alicia, Sunhee . . .

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Julia Alvarez***
***Book: What Saves Us, pg 4***
***ISBN: 978-0810140776***
***Publisher: Curbstone Books 2***
***Date (Month/Year): Oct 2019***

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## Home by Warsan Shire

*Warsan Shire is a poet and activist who was born in Kenya to Somali parents. The family immigrated to London when Warsan was a young child.*

no one leaves home unless
home is the mouth of a shark
you only run for the border
when you see the whole city running as well
your neighbors running faster than you
breath bloody in their throats

you only leave home
when home won't let you stay.

you have to understand,
that no one puts their children in a boat
unless the water is safer than the land

no one spends days and nights in the stomach of a truck
feeding on newspaper unless the miles travelled
means something more than journey.
no one crawls under fences
no one wants to be beaten
pitied

no one chooses refugee camps
or strip searches where your
body is left aching
or prison,
because prison is safer
than a city of fire
and one prison guard
in the night
is better than a truckload
of men who look like your father

no one could take it
no one could stomach it
no one skin would be tough enough

the
go home

blacks
refugees
dirty immigrants
asylum seekers

sucking our country dry

niggers with their hands out

they smell strange

savage

messed up their country and now they want

to mess ours up

how do the words

the dirty looks

roll off your backs

maybe because the blow is softer

than a limb torn off

i want to go home,

but home is the mouth of a shark

home is the barrel of a gun

and no one would leave home

unless home chased you to the shore

unless home told you

to leave your clothes behind

crawl through the desert

wade through the oceans

drown

be hungry

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beg

forget pride

your survival is more important

no one leaves home

until home is a sweaty voice in your ear

saying-

leave,

run away from me now

i dont know what i've become

but i know that anywhere

is safer than here

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Warsan Shire***
***Book: Bless the Daughter Raised by a Voice in Her Head: Poems***
***ISBN: 978-0593134351***
***Publisher: Random House Trade Paperbacks***
***Date (Month/Year): March 2022***

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